Ramananda Raya

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“Different Only in Body”

When Sri Chaitanya, back from His pilgrimage through the south, first received Bhavananda Raya in Nilachala, He embraced him and spoke words that Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami preserved in his list of the branches of the Chaitanya tree:

“Embracing Bhavananda Raya, Sri Chaitanya said: ‘Formerly you were King Pandu, and your five sons are the Pandavas. <…> Your five sons are indescribably dear to Me. But Ramananda Raya is so dear to Me that I feel Myself one with him; we differ only in our bodies.’” (CC, Adi 10.132, 134)

Kaviraja names Bhavananda’s five sons one by one: Ramananda Raya, the eldest, then Gopinatha Pattanayaka, Kalanidhi, Sudhanidhi and Vaninatha (Nayaka) (CC, Adi 10.133). Of them it was Ramananda who was destined to become the one through whom the Lord revealed to the world the hidden science of rasa. Statesman and governor, poet and pandit, skilled in everything, he was also the best of the mahabhagavatas — those who belong wholly to the Lord.

The House of Bhavananda

Six kroshas (about twelve miles) west of Puri lies the ancient holy place of Brahmagiri, or Alalanatha. It is said that already in Satya-yuga Brahma performed bhajana here. Later the southern Alvars — the divyasuris — came and installed the four-armed Deity of Janardana, whom they served according to the Pancharatra. The very name “Alalanatha” is a corruption of “Alvar-natha”, “Lord of the Alvars”; to this day the villages around are called Alvarpattanam, Alarapur and similar names.

Not far from Alalanatha lived a landholder, Bhavananda Raya, a great bhagavata. He belonged to the Oriya service community of the karanas, akin to the kayasthas of Bengal (his own lineage is called “shaukra-karana”), and lived at Brahmagiri; his second son was Gopinatha. Oriya society counts the karanas among the shudras, and so Ramananda too was taken for a shudra. But Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, retelling in his “Anubhashya” the history of the family written by Ramananda’s descendant Manohara Raya, remarks that though born in this community, Ramananda was in truth a brahmana, and as a Vaishnava paramahamsa, the guru of brahmanas.

Of the place of his appearance only a local tradition survives. In the Bengali year 1337 (about 1930), when Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati visited Alalanatha with his disciples, the local people told him that Ramananda Raya had been born in Bhavananda’s house in the village of Bentpur, a mile from Alalanatha. Bhavananda’s descendants, bearing the family title “Chaudhuri Pattanayaka”, live there still. According to the same people, Sri Chaitanya came to Brahmagiri every year to see Alalanatha and the place where Ramananda had appeared. Neither the day nor the year of his appearance is given in the biographies.

Governor on the Godavari

The independent king of Orissa at that time was Gajapati Prataparudra. Ramananda served him as trusted governor of the southern lands — East and West Godavari, with their capital at Vidyanagara; later he became one of the king’s ministers. His brother Gopinatha Pattanayaka was also in the king’s service; he once squandered part of the treasury and, having roused the prince’s anger, was already raised onto the scaffold for execution; but Prataparudra, remembering how close Gopinatha was to Mahaprabhu and to Ramananda, pardoned him — of which more below. Another brother, Vaninatha

Pattanayaka, later served the Lord in Puri in many ways, among them by bringing Him maha-prasada.

Prataparudra was a mighty commander, yet a humble and generous Vaishnava and a patron of learning; so he appears in Ramananda's own drama as well. Ramananda, Kashi Mishra and Sarvabhauma loved their king. Of Ramananda's spiritual lineage only one testimony has come down: the "Bhajana-nirnaya" calls him a disciple of Raghavendra Puri, a disciple of Madhavendra Puri.

Friends in Nilachala

In Puri Ramananda had two special friends, bound to him by eternal friendship — both from Navadvipa, both having left their former ashrama to live by Jagannatha as kshetra-sannyasis. The first was Vasudeva Sarvabhauma, son of Maheshvara Visharada of the Vidyanagara quarter of Navadvipa. The second was Purushottama Acharya, likewise once a resident of Navadvipa and later known as Svarupa Damodara; with him, it is said, Ramananda was "one soul".

Sarvabhauma did not understand his friend at first. Himself a smarta brahmana who had taken renunciation at the holy place, he saw in Ramananda only a worldly shudra of the karana caste, did not grasp the meaning of his words and deeds, and mocked him. But when by the Lord's mercy Sarvabhauma himself came to know pure bhakti, Ramananda's greatness too was revealed to him. Even so learned a man failed, without mercy, to recognise either the Lord or His devotee: the greatness of the Lord and of those who are His is known only by their mercy.

Mahaprabhu took sannyasa in the month of Magha, came to Puri in Phalguna, delivered Sarvabhauma after the Dola-yatra in Chaitra, and in Vaishakha set out for the south; at Nityananda's insistence He took a servant, Krishnadasa, with Him. At parting Sarvabhauma gave Him four kaupinas and outer cloths and earnestly begged:

"In the town of Vidyanagara on the bank of the Godavari lives a man worthy in every respect, named Ramananda Raya. Please, be sure to meet him, and do not reject him because by birth he is a shudra. He is the most fit of all to be Your associate, for in the whole world there is no rasika devotee like him. He is at once an eminent pandit and the greatest knower of bhakti-rasa. If You meet him, You will surely be convinced of it. When I came to know him, I could not appreciate the extraordinary spiritual depth of his words and deeds, and I mocked him simply because he was a Vaishnava. By Your mercy I can now understand the truth of what he spoke. Speak with him, and You will understand his greatness." (CC, Madhya 7.62–67)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains on these verses that outwardly Ramananda was not a sannyasi, but he was learned, renounced in substance, a perfect man; and Sarvabhauma, having become a Vaishnava, recognised in him a true rasika devotee, worthy of every honour.

The Meeting on the Godavari

Passing Kurmasthana, where He healed the leper Vasudeva, and Simhachalam, where He danced before Jiyada-Nrisimha, the Lord on the following day came to the Godavari in ecstasy, dancing and singing.[1] The river reminded Him of the Yamuna, and the forest on its bank of Vrindavana, and He danced there for a while. Having crossed over, He bathed at Goshpada-tirtha, by present-day Kovvur on the western bank, and sat down to sing the names of Krishna, hoping to meet Ramananda. Just then, to the sound of music and with a splendid procession, a royal dignitary arrived at the river in a palanquin, and with him many Vedic brahmanas who had come to bathe and offer tarpana. The Lord understood that this was Ramananda Raya himself — the governor of Rajamahendri.[2]

Ramananda stepped down from the palanquin. Seeing an extraordinary sannyasi — radiant as the sun, in saffron cloth, of mighty build, with eyes like lotuses — he ran up and prostrated himself before Him.

The Lord, outwardly restraining Himself, raised him and asked, “Are you Ramananda Raya?” “I am a wretched shudra, a servant of Your servants,” he humbly replied. Then the Lord embraced him tightly, and both, losing outer consciousness, fell to the ground. “Sacred mutual love awoke in them. As soon as they embraced, they fell to the ground” (CC, Madhya 8.23). In both appeared all eight spiritual transformations, and from their lips “Krishna” broke out in a faltering voice. The brahmanas were bewildered and stood as if painted:

“In this sannyasi we see the effulgence of Brahman. So why does He weep, embracing a shudra? Ramananda Raya is the wise governor of Madras and a great pandit. But, having touched this sannyasi, he has lost his composure and begun to behave like a madman.” (CC, Madhya 8.26–27)

Seeing outsiders who knew nothing of bhakti, the Lord checked His feelings and said that He had come at Sarvabhauma’s request. Ramananda called himself a royal servant, a worldly man, the lowest of shudras and an untouchable, and glorified the Lord as One who, having no purpose of His own, comes to deliver the fallen:

“You granted Sarvabhauma such mercy only because of his love for You. And that You have touched me, an untouchable, confirms it. You are the Supreme Lord Narayana Himself, while I am only an ordinary official, sunk in worldliness, the lowest of shudras. Unafraid of the injunctions of the Vedas, without a trace of aversion You have touched me.” (CC, Madhya 8.34–36)

Meanwhile the hearts of the brahmanas themselves — men of ritual who had never loved bhakti — melted at the sight of the Lord and His acts: “Krishna” and “Hari” sounded on their lips, and signs of love appeared on their bodies. Ramananda said that this was possible only by the power of Bhagavan Himself, manifest before their eyes: in form and in nature alike the Lord is God. Seeing that He had been recognised, the Lord tried to hide behind humble words and began to praise Ramananda:

“You are the best of the mahabhagavatas, souls wholly devoted to God,” the Lord said. “The hearts of all people simply melt at the sight of you. What to speak of others, when I, a Mayavadi sannyasi, have plunged into an ocean of love for Krishna simply by touching you.” (CC, Madhya 8.44–45)

Just then a Vaishnava brahmana invited the Lord to his home for bhiksha. The Lord expressed His wish to meet again, and Ramananda pleaded:

“Though You have come to correct me, one meeting will not be enough to purify my heart. Please stay at least a week and cleanse my polluted mind.” (CC, Madhya 8.51–52)

Nights of Conversation

In the evening, when the Lord had taken bhiksha, bathed and was resting, Ramananda came to Him with a single servant. So began the conversation that Krishnadasa Kaviraja relates in the eighth chapter of the Madhya-lila, which he opens thus:

“Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu is like a boundless ocean of knowledge of loving service to God. He filled the heart of Ramananda Raya with this nectar and then commanded him to become like a cloud and pour the rain of these life-giving truths over that very ocean, thus filling it with the jewels of the highest conclusions.” (CC, Madhya 8.1)

The Lord asked and Ramananda answered — but he answered by a power that the Lord Himself had placed in him. So the Lord became the questioner and made His devotee the teacher, in order to preach dharma through him.

“Recite a shloka about the goal of life,” the Lord asked. Ramananda began with varnashrama-dharma. “This is external; tell Me further,” the Lord replied. Then Ramananda named the offering of the fruits of one’s acts to God, then the giving up of duties for the sake of devotion, then bhakti mixed with

knowledge — and each time he heard: “This too is external.” Only when he named pure bhakti, free from speculative knowledge, did the Lord accept it as the true goal. The order shows that everything outside the Vedic norms is rejected at once, yet even the stages of varnashrama and the offering of fruits are only external; pure bhakti begins with hearing of Krishna from the lips of a pure devotee, and “freedom from knowledge” rejects impersonal knowledge, not knowledge of one’s relationship with God.

The Lord asked him to go deeper still, and Ramananda said:

“The essence of all perfection is prema-bhakti, unalloyed nectarean devotion to God.” (CC, Madhya 8.68)

In support he cited a verse of his own composition, later included by Sri Rupa in the “Padyavali”:

“The feeling of hunger and thirst turns eating and drinking into a great pleasure. So too any activity performed as loving worship of the Lord fills the devotee’s heart with bliss.” (CC, Madhya 8.69)

It is followed by another verse of the “Padyavali” — “krishna-bhakti-rasa-bhavita matih…”, which in some places is also ascribed to Ramananda:

“The sweetness of bhakti, in which one’s individual relationship with Krishna unfolds, cannot be attained even by performing pious deeds for millions of births in a row. Only one thing is needed — an ardent desire to obtain such unalloyed devotion without delay, wherever it may be found.” (CC, Madhya 8.70)

Then, step by step, Ramananda described love for Krishna — pure attachment (krishna-rati), servitude (dasya), friendship (sakhya), parental love (vatsalya) and, as the essence of all goals, the love of lovers (kantabhava); above it, the love of Sri Radhika; then the nature of Krishna, the nature of Radha, the nature of rasa and of prema. When the Lord asked for more, Ramananda sang his own song about the highest feeling of separation — adhirudha-bhava — about “prema-vilasa-vivarta”, the “reversal” of loving play; and the Lord acknowledged it as the limit of the goal (CC, Madhya 8.193; on the song, see the section “Writings”).

Then the Lord asked about the means, and Ramananda replied that it was the Lord Himself who spoke through his lips and the Lord Himself who listened. The only means of attaining the service of Radha and Krishna is to follow the sakhis of Vraja: Radha is the creeper of love for Krishna, and the sakhis are its shoots, flowers and leaves; without following the gopis, the service of the son of the king of Vraja cannot be attained.

So night after night passed in talks of Krishna. At another time the Lord put short questions, and Ramananda answered each with a single word of truth:

“‘Which glory is the best?’ ‘To be a devotee of Krishna — that is the highest glory.’ <…> ‘Of all sufferings, which is the most painful?’ ‘I see no greater misfortune than separation from a devotee of Krishna.’ <…> ‘What brings the soul the highest good?’ ‘Only the company of a devotee of Krishna brings the soul true good.’ <…> ‘Where should one live, rejecting all else?’ ‘One should live in the land of Vraja, where the Rasa-lila took place.’” (CC, Madhya 8.245, 247, 250, 253)

And of those who seek liberation or worldly pleasure Ramananda said: not knowing their relationship with God, people are like crows pecking at the bitter fruits of the nimba tree, while those who have come to know it are like cuckoos tasting the nectarean buds of the mango (CC, Madhya 8.256–258). Ramananda humbly begged the Lord to stay at least ten days. “What are ten days!” the Lord answered. “I will not part from you all My life: we shall live together in Nilachala.”

The Secret of the Golden Form

Several nights passed, and one day Ramananda saw the Lord differently. Before, a sannyasi had stood before him — now he saw a dark form, and before it a golden figure whose radiance covered His whole body:

“You resemble a golden deity wrapped in golden radiance. I see a flute at Your lips, and Your lotus eyes are ever in motion. This form of Yours fills me with wonder. O Lord, reveal to me its cause and hide nothing.” (CC, Madhya 8.268–270)

At first the Lord evaded him: a mahabhagavata, He said, sees his beloved Deity everywhere, and Ramananda simply sees Radha and Krishna wherever he looks. But Ramananda would not yield:

“O Lord! Leave aside these philosophical words. Be merciful, do not hide Your true form from me. You have descended, taking the heart and radiance of Radharani, to taste Your own sweetness. <…> You came to save me, and now You are trying to deceive me. Why do You act so?” (CC, Madhya 8.277–278, 280)

“Then, with a smile on His lips, Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu showed him His form as Krishna and Radharani united in one, Rasaraja and Mahabhava, the abode of all spiritual rasas and the highest embodiment of prema. Seeing this, Ramananda Raya lost consciousness in bliss and fell to the ground.” (CC, Madhya 8.281–282)

The Lord restored him to consciousness with the touch of His hand, embraced and comforted him. No one but Ramananda had seen this form: to him, who knew all His pastimes and rasas, the Lord disclosed the hidden reasons why Krishna had taken the feeling and radiance of Radha — and forbade him to reveal this secret:

“My body is not fair; it only seems so from contact with the body of Radha. But She touches no one but the son of Nanda Maharaja. So My body and mind have been transformed by Her ecstatic feeling, and now I can taste My own sweetness. <…> Keep all this secret and tell no one, for people will laugh, taking it all for madness. In truth we are both madmen, and in this we are very alike.” (CC, Madhya 8.286–287, 289–290)

Ten nights the Lord spent with Ramananda on the Godavari. On leaving, He said to him:

“Give up worldly affairs and come to Jagannatha Puri. When I have finished My pilgrimage, I too shall return there. We shall live together in Nilachala, delighting in talks of Krishna.” (CC, Madhya 8.296–297)

All these conversations were written down in his diary (kadacha) by Ramananda’s close friend Svarupa Damodara; it was from this kadacha that Krishnadasa Kaviraja retold them in detail.

The Meeting as Told by Murari Gupta and Lochana Dasa

The oldest biographies tell of this meeting differently. In Murari Gupta’s kadacha the Lord, singing of Hari, goes one clear morning to the city of Kanchi to see Ramananda:

“Ramananda, in his own house, having finished his worship of Krishna, was meditating on the Supreme Brahman, the son of the king of Vraja — and three times he beheld the great and wondrous sweetness of Gauranga, and was utterly astonished. Opening his eyes, he saw that very form — the Supreme Brahman in the dress of a sannyasi. Bowing his head to the ground and joining his palms, he asked, ‘Where have You come from, my Lord?’ The Lord laughed and said, ‘How can you not remember, O bee at the lotus feet of Sri Radhika?’ And having thus made Himself known, Hari Himself embraced him with both arms.” (Murari Gupta, “Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charitamrita”, 3.15.2–4)

Having revealed to him the wondrous secret of the pastimes in the forests of Vrindavana, the Lord bade him go quickly to Kshetra (Puri), comforted him and went His way (ibid., 3.15.5).

Lochana Dasa took this account from Murari. In his "Chaitanya-mangala" the Lord, after visiting Jiyada-Nrisimha, comes to Kanchi-nagara, to the gates of the royal palace, and asks about the prince. The gatekeeper replies that the prince is in the inner apartments, engaged in worship. That prince was Ramananda, Bhavananda's son. He was chanting the maha-mantra and meditating on Krishna, but instead of Shyamasundara he saw the unheard-of form of Gaurasundara; and opening his eyes, he saw Him in person: unnoticed by any of the guards, Gaurasundara had entered his apartments and given him darshana in his "temple of meditation".

Astonished, Ramananda asked how a sannyasi had come in to him.

"The Lord says: 'Why do you not know your own self? You do not recognise Me — and I have come to take you.' <…> Hearing this, the Lord laughed aloud; the Lord makes Himself known and reveals Himself. All that was there — dark, white, red — everything appears as one golden form." ("Chaitanya-mangala", Shesha-khanda 104–106)

Then the Lord became dark, like a kanada flower, with a peacock feather on His head and a flute at His lips, in yellow garments and a forest garland — and golden again, so that beasts, birds, trees and creepers glittered in the radiance of His body. Understanding who stood before him, Ramananda, overcome with love, fell weeping at the feet of his Lord, and the Lord, taking him by the hand, led him outside (ibid., 107–113). Elsewhere in the "Chaitanya-mangala" too Ramananda is named among the eternal associates of the Lord.[3]

Return from the South and Arrival in Puri

Having visited many holy places of the south, the Lord returned to Vidyanagara along the seven branches of the Godavari. Ramananda came to Him, and their talks began anew. The Lord told him of His pilgrimage and handed him two manuscripts He had found in the south — the "Krishna-karnamrita" and the "Brahma-samhita": "Here are the proofs of all your conclusions about rasa." Ramananda relished them together with the Lord and made copies of both. This time the Lord stayed with him for about another week. Ramananda could not follow Him at once: he had to wait for the king's permission and set his affairs in order. He promised to come to Puri as soon as he could.

In Puri the Lord settled in the house of Kashi Mishra. There Bhavananda came to Him, and the Lord glorified his son in his presence:

"Your son Ramananda is like the greatest of jewels. His greatness and glory cannot be described in this mortal world. You are Maharaja Pandu himself, your wife is Kunti, and your five wise sons are manifestations of the five famous sons of Pandu." (CC, Madhya 10.52–53)

Bhavananda humbly called himself a lowly shudra sunk in worldliness, surrendered everything at the Lord's feet and gave Him his son Vaninatha for constant service. The Lord kept Vaninatha with Him and said that Ramananda would soon arrive.

Meanwhile Ramananda, at the Lord's bidding, had handed over his duties to a successor and petitioned the king for retirement, so as to spend the rest of his life with the Lord. A few days later Prataparudra, with Ramananda and other courtiers, came from his capital Cuttack to Puri, and Ramananda hastened first of all to the Lord's feet (CC, Madhya 11.15).[4] He told Him that he had conveyed His will to the king: that he should leave the royal service. The king had gladly agreed, saying that no one is more fortunate than one who serves the feet of Chaitanya, and had promised to pay him his full salary even after retirement. Ramananda also told the Lord how greatly the king loved Him and longed to meet

Him. “The king will be blessed by serving such a mahabhagavata,” the Lord replied, and added:

“King Prataparudra has such strong love for you, and because of this quality Krishna will surely accept him. [Lord Krishna said to Arjuna:] ‘Those who call themselves My devotees are not such. I consider My true devotees only those who serve My devotees.’” (CC, Madhya 11.27–28)

In Puri Ramananda met and honoured those gathered around the Lord — Nityananda, Paramananda Puri, Brahmananda Bharati, Svarupa Damodara, Jagadananda, Mukunda and others. It was here, according to one of the biographies, that Svarupa and Jagadananda came to know him. “Have you seen Jagannatha?” the Lord asked him. Ramananda replied that he would soon go to Him, and when asked why, then, he had come here first, he said: “The feet are only the chariot, and the heart is the charioteer: wherever the charioteer drives, there the chariot goes.” Then at the Lord’s bidding he went to Jagannatha, and afterwards to his family.

Intercessor for the King

Prataparudra longed with all his heart to see the Lord, but the Lord, a sannyasi, would not agree to meet a king. When Nityananda sent the king one of the Lord’s kaupinas for consolation, the king began earnestly to beg Ramananda to intercede. Through him he sent word that he was ready to give up his life if he did not see the Lord. The minister, skilled in affairs, again and again told the Lord of the king’s Vaishnava qualities and of his love for His feet — and the Lord’s heart softened.

“What am I, a sannyasi, to do?” the Lord asked. Ramananda called Him the Master who stands above all injunctions and prohibitions. The Lord replied that He was bound by rules, yet He could not refuse His friend outright, so close were they:

“A pot may be full of milk, but a drop of wine can spoil it completely, and then no one wants it. No doubt the king has many virtues, but the royal title spoils everything. Yet if you still wish this meeting to take place, then bring his son to Me. The scriptures say, ‘The father manifests himself in the son’, and so, meeting the prince, I shall in effect be meeting the king himself.” (CC, Madhya 12.53–56)

Ramananda brought the young prince to the Lord. The dark-complexioned boy awakened in the Lord the remembrance of Krishna. And a few days later, in the garden of Balagandi, during the Ratha-yatra, Prataparudra, alone, in the dress of a simple Vaishnava, reciting shlokas of the “Bhagavatam”, was blessed to massage the feet of the Lord, who was absorbed in love for Krishna.

Seeing the Lord off to Vrindavana

Of the first years the Lord spent in Nilachala after sannyasa, two went to the journey south and back, and for two more He wished to go to Vrindavana but could not set out: Ramananda and Sarvabhauma, at the king’s special request, did all they could to keep Him in Puri and put various obstacles in His way. At last they gave in.

After Vijaya-dashami the Lord set out by way of Gauda. Ramananda came with Him to Cuttack, where in a garden under a bakula tree the Lord met Prataparudra; and then, when the Lord crossed the Chitrotpala, he went on after Him together with Mangaraja and Harichandana. Only at Remuna did the Lord send him back.[5] That parting cannot be described in words:

“Unable to bear the pain of separation, Ramananda Raya lost consciousness and fell to the ground, and Sri Chaitanya laid his head on His lap and wept. The Lord Himself could not bear separation from Ramananda Raya. I am simply unable to describe such intensity of spiritual feeling.” (CC, Madhya 16.154–155)

That year the Lord did not reach Vrindavana: at Ramakeli He received Sanatana and Rupa and, returning through Shantipura, where He instructed Raghunatha dasa, came back to Nilachala. Among those who met Him then were Kashi Mishra, Ramananda, Pradyumna, Sarvabhauma, Vaninatha and Shikhi Mahiti (CC, Madhya 16.254). In the autumn the Lord again wished to go to Vrindavana and secretly consulted Ramananda and Svarupa. He wanted to go alone, by night, through the forests (cf. CC, Madhya 17.5–6), but they persuaded Him to take companions and gave Him Balabhadra Bhattacharya and another brahmana. And when the Lord, having visited Vrindavana, Prayaga and Kashi, returned through Jharikhanda, Ramananda came from Cuttack to see Him.

Rupa and Sanatana

At Prayaga the Lord placed in Sri Rupa's heart all that He Himself had once heard from Ramananda's lips:

"There He revealed to Sri Rupa the highest truths about Krishna, teaching him the highest conclusions of the science of bhakti and the rasas in full agreement with the 'Srimad-Bhagavatam'. He told him all those confidential conclusions that He had heard before from Ramananda Raya. By His mercy Sri Rupa was able to grasp them perfectly." (CC, Madhya 19.115–116)

And later in Kashi, instructing Sanatana, the Lord repeated what had happened on the Godavari, only with the roles changed: then the Lord had asked and Ramananda had answered by His power; now Sanatana asked by the Lord's power, and the Lord answered. Ramananda's conversation and Sanatana's questions alike draw the line between the means (sadhana) and the goal (sadhya).

When Rupa came to Puri and stayed with Haridasa Thakura, he was writing two dramas — the "Vidagdha-madhava" and the "Lalita-madhava"; the greater part of the first was composed in the Lord's presence. One day the Lord came to him together with Svarupa, Ramananda and Sarvabhauma. When Svarupa read out Rupa's verse "priyah so 'yam", Ramananda and Sarvabhauma told the Lord that without His mercy no one could have expressed His innermost feelings. After the verse "tunde tandavini" Ramananda asked Rupa what book he was writing; Svarupa told him of the two dramas. Ramananda had him recite the nandi-shloka and the verse of blessing "anarpita-charim chirat…", then the shloka on his chosen Deity — "in the company of Vaishnavas there is nothing to be shy of" — and questioned him on every part of both plays. Rupa spoke humbly of Ramananda's greatness. The Lord, feigning displeasure, said, "I am ashamed, and people will laugh," but Ramananda, unsparing in his praise, replied: "This is not poetry but a stream of nectar, with a drop of camphor in it. People will only rejoice, for Rupa is simply remembering his Deity." So they talked of dramaturgy, and Ramananda repeated that such poetry was possible only by the Lord's mercy. Rupa revered him so much that, according to one interpretation, he saw in him those very sakhis whom Rupa-manjari follows in the eternal pastimes — Lalita and Vishakha (Ramananda himself in the Vraja-lila is Vishakha; see the section "In the Eternal Pastimes").

Then the Lord asked everyone to bless Rupa, and to Ramananda He spoke of Rupa's elder brother:

"I ask all of you to bless Rupa Gosvami, so that he may ceaselessly describe these pastimes of Vrindavana, full of divine rasas towards Krishna. His elder brother, Sanatana, is so wise and learned that there is no one to compare with him. His detachment from all worldly things is as strong as yours, Ramananda." (CC, Antya 1.199–201)

So the Lord Himself declared equal the renunciation of two very different devotees. Sanatana slept each night under a new tree and chewed dry cakes of chickpea flour; Ramananda, remaining outwardly a householder and a dignitary, was the best teacher of yukta-vairagya — the renunciation in which everything is given to the service of Krishna. Both nourished the rasa of the Lord's separation.

Ramananda's renunciation, like Sanatana's, is not a dry rejection of the world but the summit of thirst for Krishna's pastimes; in this Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati stand beside them.

Pradyumna Mishra and the Devadasis

To reveal Ramananda's greatness to the world, the Lord performed a special pastime. One day the brahmana Pradyumna Mishra from Shrihatta came to Him and asked Him to speak about Krishna. The Lord replied that He Himself heard about Krishna from Ramananda and that only Ramananda knew such talks: let the Mishra go to him. The "Chaitanya-bhagavata" names Pradyumna Mishra, Paramananda Mahapatra and Ramananda among the natives of Orissa who came to the Lord: Pradyumna is "the embodiment of divine love", while Paramananda and Ramananda are "two very great saints" (CB, Antya 3.184).

The Mishra went to Ramananda's house and learned from a servant that his host had taken two very beautiful young devadasis — girls dedicated to the service of Jagannatha (in Orissa they are called "mahari") — into a secluded garden and was teaching them the songs and dance of his drama, which was staged in the temple for Jagannatha's pleasure. Krishnadasa Kaviraja explains who Ramananda was in this service:

"The touch of the young dancers in no way affected his mind and body, as if he were touching wood or stone. He felt himself a maidservant of the gopis of Vraja and performed his service in natural spiritual feeling (regarding those maidens as the cowherd girls of Vrindavana). The glory and greatness of the associates of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu are practically inconceivable. And in Ramananda Raya we find the highest limit of love and devotion to Krishna. <…> Every day he taught them to dance. Can tiny conditioned souls understand the greatness of Ramananda Raya's mind and heart?" (CC, Antya 5.19–21, 26)

Ramananda — a soul satisfied in the self, higher than any renounced sage, victorious over every impulse of the senses — saw no flesh in the girls. In his spiritual body (siddha-deha), in the mood of a gopi, he performed spontaneous, ragatmika bhakti and served his mistress, the daughter of Vrishabhanu. He honoured the performers as the chief gopis, the objects of his service, and himself as Radha's maidservant, and served them without the slightest worldly attraction: he himself bathed, dressed and adorned them, and did not only teach them songs and dance.

Hearing of the guest, Ramananda, having finished the lesson, came out to the reception room, honoured the Mishra and asked forgiveness for the delay. But the Mishra, having waited long and heard much from the servant about his host's conduct, had lost faith in him at heart; seeing the late hour, he scarcely spoke and went home. When the Lord asked him what he had heard, the Mishra told Him what he had seen and heard. In reply the Lord glorified Ramananda:

"Although Sri Ramananda Raya teaches these girls to express various spiritual emotions, his mind remains calm and unmoved. And even touching young girls, his mind and body remain unmoved, as though they were made of wood or stone. Truly, this is the wonder of wonders! Only Ramananda Raya can act so. Now it is clear to Me that his body only seems material. In reality it is wholly spiritual." (CC, Antya 5.40–42)

The Lord also cited the words of the "Bhagavatam": whoever hears with faith of Krishna's rasa-lila with the girls of Vraja is freed from lust — the disease of the heart — and attains pure love (CC, Antya 5.45–48; Bhag. 10.33.39). And He concluded:

"We understand that Sri Ramananda Raya has entered the path of spontaneous love for God, which transcends all rules and regulations. And since his whole body is wholly spiritual, his mind too is

beyond the influence of maya." (CC, Antya 5.51)

Ramananda is an eternally perfect associate of the Lord. For the sake of the pastimes, by Krishna's will, he shows himself in a body that is called "almost perfect", as though awaiting the full attainment of his eternal form,[6] — and therefore in that transcendental body there is not a shadow of worldly change. To judge such a Vaishnava by birth and outward conduct, by a worldly measure, is not to understand him at all: the "Padma Purana" plainly warns against seeing in a Vaishnava his earthly caste. "Go to him again," the Lord told the Mishra, "and say that I have sent you. I Myself hear about Krishna from Ramananda."

The Mishra came again and conveyed the Lord's words. When Ramananda asked what he wished to hear, the Mishra asked him to tell in order all that he had spoken to the Lord in Vidyanagara. Both were absorbed in talk of Krishna, and the Mishra came to know Ramananda's greatness; as he left, he broke into a dance of jubilation (CC, Antya 5.67). In the evening, having bathed and eaten, he returned to the Lord and said:

"No one can retell the talks with Ramananda Raya. He cannot be considered an ordinary man, for he is full of the transcendental rasas of loving devotion to Krishna. Ramananda Raya also told me: 'You should not think that it is I who explain to you the pastimes and qualities of Krishna. Sri Chaitanya Himself speaks through me. I am only like a musical instrument (a vina) — He draws from me whatever sounds He Himself desires.'" (CC, Antya 5.71–73)

The Lord answered with fresh praise:

"Know that Ramananda's great humility has no equal. He often attributes his own words to others. Such is the inner nature of great souls who constantly feel loving devotion to Krishna in their hearts — they will never glorify themselves." (CC, Antya 5.77–78)

"Though Ramananda Raya was a family man, he was not subject to the six vices (lust, anger, greed, bewilderment, madness and envy). Though he outwardly continued to live in the world, he gave instruction to renounced monks." (CC, Antya 5.80)

Why, then, did the Lord send the Mishra? Kaviraja answers:

"And so that Ramananda Raya might reveal his saintly qualities, Sri Chaitanya sent Pradyumna Mishra to him to hear about Krishna. <…> Wishing to destroy the arrogance of proud theologians and monks, Lord Chaitanya sometimes teaches dharma even through the low-born (shudras). Sri Chaitanya came to preach love and devotion to Krishna, as well as the nature of the Absolute Truth. By His sweet will He made Ramananda Raya the speaker, while He Himself, together with Pradyumna Mishra, became his humble listener." (CC, Antya 5.81, 84–85)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains that to the worldly eye Ramananda seemed a householder on the path of worldly action, but he was a Vaishnava householder who had attained the transcendent, free from the six enemies; he was wholly turned to Krishna and able to turn even renounced impersonalist sannyasis to bhakti. Through a "shudra" and a "grihastha" the Lord instructed Pradyumna, a brahmana by birth, and Himself accepted the dharma that Ramananda preached: Pradyumna listened to Ramananda — born not in a brahmana family, yet the finest teacher of bhakti-rasa, a Vaishnava acharya — "as a disciple", and so obtained the causeless mercy of the Lord. Kaviraja himself does not here call Ramananda "low" in his own voice: Ramananda merely displayed the pastime of birth in a humble family, to teach that anyone who has the highest love for Krishna is a guru of the world, whatever his birth. Ramananda is the teacher of brahmanas and sannyasis, a guru even for the eternally perfect teachers of the world. And the "Bhakti-ratnakara" says that "through Ramananda" the Lord displayed the crushing of the pride of Kandarpa, the god of love ("Bhakti-ratnakara", 1.630).

Vallabha Bhatta, Gopinatha, Haridasa

When the learned Vallabha Bhatta came to Puri, the Lord, speaking of Himself with pointed humility, glorified Ramananda before him as His teacher:

“And Srila Ramananda Raya is an unsurpassed knower of all kinds of relationship with Krishna (rasas). He explained to Me the supreme position of Krishna as the original Bhagavan, the source of all forms and moods of God. Ramananda Raya revealed to Me that unalloyed love for Krishna is the highest of life’s goals. And among all loving moods, the highest perfection is granted by the path of pure spontaneous attraction. <…> All these truths were told to Me by Sri Ramananda Raya, who possesses unsurpassed knowledge of the rasas (transcendental relationships with God). Truly, to hear him is the highest bliss. The power of Sri Ramananda Raya cannot be described in words. By his mercy the pure love of the residents of Vrindavana for Krishna was revealed to Me.” (CC, Antya 7.23–24, 36–37)

Between these words the Lord explained that love born of awareness of Krishna’s majesty does not lead to Vrindavana, while the pure (kevala) love of Vraja forgets majesty and is therefore higher than it (CC, Antya 7.25–35). Thus for the Lord Ramananda was the knower both of the relationship with God and of the highest goal, the finest connoisseur of the pure rasas of Vrindavana.

Others too saw the Lord’s mercy upon Ramananda. His brother Gopinatha Pattanayaka, whom the king pardoned when he was already on the scaffold,[7] said to the Lord:

“You have poured Your mercy in full upon Ramananda Raya and Vaninatha, freeing them from everything worldly. But I have not been granted such mercy. Please give me Your pure mercy, ridding me of attachment to the world.” (CC, Antya 9.138–139)

Ramananda was in Nilachala also when Haridasa Thakura departed: “Before all these great devotees, such as Ramananda Raya and Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya, Sri Chaitanya began to glorify the saintly qualities of Haridasa” (CC, Antya 11.50). When Nityananda came to Nilachala, Ramananda, Svarupa and Haridasa bowed to Him with special reverence.

Intimate Companion in Separation

Of all Gaura’s devotees only “three and a half” belonged to the innermost circle of Srimati Radharani:

“In this whole universe only three and a half worthy devotees were of the closest personal entourage of Srimati Radharani. These three are Svarupa Damodara, Ramananda Raya and Shikhi Mahiti, and the half is his sister Madhavi.” (CC, Antya 2.105–106)

The Lord Himself told Prataparudra that He had come to Purushottama for the sake of three: “I have come here for the sake of three persons: you, Sarvabhauma and Ramananda Raya” (CB, Antya 5.202).

With the Lord, according to Kaviraja, different devotees were bound by different rasas:

“Sri Chaitanya relished the feelings of parental love with Paramananda Puri, friendship with Ramananda Raya, servitude with Govinda and others, and the rasa of conjugal love with Gadadhara, Jagadananda and Svarupa Damodara.” (CC, Madhya 2.78)

At the same time Ramananda, Gadadhara and Svarupa are named the chief energies of madhura-rasa — the Lord’s helpers in tasting separation.

In the last years, when the Lord lived day and night in separation from Krishna, by day He sang the names and went for darshana of Jagannatha, and by night He tasted the rasa of love for Krishna with two constant companions — Ramananda and Svarupa:

“When Sri Chaitanya suffered the severe pangs of separation from Krishna, Ramananda Raya told Him about Krishna and Svarupa Damodara sang. And only this kept Him alive. <…> As the cowherd boy

Subala once consoled Krishna in friendship, so Ramananda Raya consoled Sri Chaitanya, who was suffering separation from Krishna. <…> No one can describe the good fortune of Ramananda Raya and Svarupa Damodara. All people sang their praises as very close associates of Sri Chaitanya." (CC, Antya 6.6, 9, 11)

By night the Lord confided to them all that lay hidden in His heart:

"With the coming of night Sri Chaitanya confided to Svarupa Damodara and Ramananda Raya all the intimate feelings of His heart. <…> Embracing Ramananda and Svarupa by the neck and wholly losing His peace and self-control, He lamented: 'Where is My Lord Hari? Where is He?'" (CC, Antya 14.40, 42)

In Gaura, overwhelmed by Radha's feeling in separation, all ten states of the gopis whose Beloved has gone away became manifest, and in those days Ramananda served the Lord by reciting shlokas suited to the moment. When the Lord vanished from His room and was found now at the Lion Gate with His body unnaturally lengthened, now in the coastal dunes, which He took for Govardhana, Ramananda and Svarupa were beside Him:

"And with these words Sri Chaitanya embraced Svarupa Damodara and Ramananda Raya by the neck and asked them: 'What am I to do now? Where shall I go and where seek Krishna? Tell Me, how can I attain Him?' <…> These two devotees tried to console Him at least a little. Svarupa Damodara sang songs in tune with Sri Chaitanya's feelings, and Ramananda Raya read aloud the poetry of the scriptures. And hearing those songs and quotations from Bilvamangala Thakura's 'Krishna-karnamrita', the poetry of Vidyapati and Jayadeva Gosvami's 'Sri Gita-govinda', Sri Chaitanya felt the greatest bliss." (CC, Antya 15.24, 26–27)

As daily the Lord relished the songs of Vidyapati and Chandidasa and Bilvamangala's "Krishna-karnamrita", so too He relished Ramananda's drama:

"With great happiness, together with Ramananda Raya and Svarupa Damodara, He sang all day and night the songs of Chandidasa and Vidyapati, and verses from the 'Gita-govinda', the 'Krishna-karnamrita' and the 'Jagannatha-vallabha-nataka'." (CC, Madhya 2.77)

Once, having received Jagannatha's vallabha-bhoga, the Lord spoke of the glory of the nectar of Krishna's lips, and at His bidding Ramananda recited verses of the "Bhagavatam" — "surata-vardhanam…" (10.31.14) and "gopyah kim acharad…" (10.21.9). With these two most intimate companions the Lord also relished, day and night in Purushottama, His own "Shikshashtaka". And through Ramananda and Svarupa He proclaimed to the world that in the age of Kali there is no path higher than harinama-sankirtana:

"In jubilation Sri Chaitanya exclaimed: 'Svarupa, Ramaraya, listen! In the age of Kali the very highest spiritual path is nama-sankirtana!'" (CC, Antya 20.8)

All this lived on in the memory of the Vaishnavas: Ramananda sang and recited verses in tune with the Lord's mood (CC, Madhya 2.77) and was among His constant companions in Puri (CC, Madhya 1.252–254); and when Mahaprabhu, Svarupa, Ramananda and the Gosvamis had gone, a "dark age", in the words of one biography, set in for the Vaishnavas. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura wrote in the "Sajjana-toshani" that false Vaishnavas slander Rupa and Ramananda, and another biography counts Svarupa, Rupa and Ramaraya among the associates who abide "within the svarupa" of the Lord. The episodes of the last years shared with Svarupa are told more fully in the article on Svarupa Damodara.

The Jagannatha-vallabha Garden

In Purushottama, roughly midway between the Gundicha and the temple of Jagannatha, there is the Jagannatha-vallabha garden. It is said to be Ramananda's place; according to some, the Deity of Radha-Govinda who abides there was served by Ramananda, and his "Jagannatha-vallabha-nataka" was staged in this garden. Here Ramananda performed his bhajana, and the garden was very dear to the Lord: on entering it, He became absorbed in love for Krishna. Once He saw Krishna there beneath an ashoka tree; the vision vanished, and the Lord fell unconscious. During the days of the "nava-ratra-yatra" the Lord lived in Jagannatha-vallabha with His devotees. And once, on the full-moon night of the month of Vaishakha, He fell here into divine madness, and Svarupa and Ramananda brought Him back to outer consciousness by various means.

Writings

The incomparable monument to Ramananda's glory is his musical drama, the "Jagannatha-vallabha-nataka", or "Ramananda-sangita-nataka"; Kaviraja calls its songs "the songs of Raya's drama". Ramananda wrote it even before he met Sri Chaitanya, at the wish — and, as the prologue says, at the command — of Prataparudra, and the king loved it; the king's name and virtues are mentioned both in the prologue and in every song. The stage-director, opening the performance, names both the author and his father:

"The poet Sri Ramananda Raya — son of Sri Bhavananda Raya, an ocean of jewel-virtues such as serenity, whose counsels, steeped in the many maxims of policy laid down by the preceptor of the gods, made the king upright and virtuous; a poet whose mind is adorned by the feet of Sri Hari — has composed and offered the musical drama of Ramananda called 'Sri Jagannatha-vallabha', dear to Gajapati Prataparudra and adorned with all these qualities." ("Jagannatha-vallabha-nataka", act 1, after verse 14)

There too sounds the praise of the king himself: "Hearing even his name, Sekandhara hides in a cave; the ornament of the land of Kalavarga looks about with tears; the king of Gurjara has come to regard his own capital as an old forest; the lord of Gauda knows himself to be as one aboard a ship on a storm-tossed ocean" (ibid., 1.10). And the king asks for "a new work, not composed in another's shadow" (ibid., 1.14): the plot of the drama is not an imitation of an old model but entirely new.

The drama has five acts: "Purva-raga" (first attraction), "Bhava-pariksha" (the testing of feeling), "Bhava-prakasha" (the revealing of feeling), "Radha-abhisara" (Radha's tryst) and "Radha-sangama" (union with Radha). Each of its twenty-one Sanskrit songs, much like the songs of Jayadeva's "Gita-govinda", ends with a line naming the poet Ramananda and Gajapati Prataparudra — "Rudra":

"May this noble form of Madhu's Enemy, sung by the poet Ramananda Raya, again and again give birth to joy in the heart of Gajapati Rudra, lord of men." (Ibid., 1.22)

Since Ramananda is an eternally perfect devotee on the path of ragatmika-bhakti, only raganugas — those who walk the path of spontaneous love and are free of anarthas — are fit to relish his drama. Its verses were rendered into Bengali padas bearing Lochana Dasa's signature; at the end of the sixteenth century one Akinchana Dasa made a verse translation of the drama (the manuscript is kept in the Calcutta University library, No. 1512); a manuscript of a translation by one Gopala Dasa is also known. The commentary "Krishna-vallabha" on the "Krishna-karnamrita" cites the drama by name.

Other works too are ascribed to Ramananda. Rajendralal Mitra's catalogue of Sanskrit manuscripts ("Notices of Sanskrit MSS.", vol. IV, No. 1672) and the "Catalogus Catalogorum" (vol. 1, p. 169) mention another five-act drama, the "Govinda-vallabha", which some regard as his. Narayana Kavi in his "Sangita-sara" cites the song "Chitrapada" from Ramananda's collection of songs, the "Kshudra-gita-prabandha"; its signature line names "Ramananda-kaviraya" and "Rudra-gajesha".

One verse of Ramananda's — "nanopachara-krita-pujanam…" — Sri Rupa included in the "Padyavali"; it is also cited in Kavi Karnapura's "Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya" and in the "Chaitanya-charitamrita", in the conversation on the Godavari (CC, Madhya 8.69). The presence in the "Padyavali" of verses by Ramananda and Karnapura is taken as evidence that Rupa compiled it after meeting the Lord. The verse "krishna-bhakti-rasa-bhavita matih…" is in some places also ascribed to Ramananda.

But his most famous song is "pahilehi raga nayana-bhange bhela…", which he sang to the Lord on the Godavari (CC, Madhya 8.193). It is the oldest song in Brajabuli and one of the brightest jewels of Vaishnava poetry; Ramananda was an incomparable poet both in Sanskrit and in Brajabuli — the "emperor of poets" of that language. Kavi Karnapura also cites the song in the thirteenth sarga of the "Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya", with the signature "vardhana-rudra- naradhipa-mana / ramananda-raya kavi bhana"; Radhamohana Thakura included it in the "Padamrita-samudra" and wrote a Sanskrit commentary on it, and it was explained in detail by Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura ("Amrita-pravaha-bhashya") and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati ("Anubhashya"):

"As soon as our eyes met, a strong attraction arose between us. Our bond grew day by day, knowing no bounds. It is not that Krishna is a youth craving enjoyment and I a maiden who grants it. Simply Cupid joined our hearts into one. O My friend! Perhaps Krishna has already forgotten Our love, but you will remind Him. <…> Now you will become the messenger, for the separation has become unbearable." (CC, Madhya 8.193)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta warns that the prakrita-sahajiyas cannot grasp the variety of pastimes and the "reversal of loving play" (vilasa-vivarta) in the highest mahabhava — in its states of mohana and madana, within "wondrous separation" (prema-vaichittya) — and drag the meaning of these lines towards impersonalism. That is why Gaurasundara covered with His hand the lips of Ramananda as they sang of Krishna — so that the secret of bhajana would not become the property of worldly philosophers. The words "neither is He the lover, nor am I the beloved" must not be taken as impersonal oneness (kevala-advaita): they only remove the suspicion of "impure duality", a self-seeking division between the lovers.

After the Lord's Disappearance

The "Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya" relates that when the Lord left for Vrindavana, Ramananda, unable to bear the separation, grew ever weaker and "gave up his life". But this "death" is not death in the ordinary sense: it is the tenth and last state of transcendental separation (dashami dasha, "marana"). According to the "Chaitanya-charitamrita", when the Lord returned from Vrindavana, Ramananda was again with Him and took part in many pastimes in Nilachala; and Murari Gupta's kadacha (4.15.1), describing the Lord's return, says that the Gajapati summoned Sarvabhauma together with Ramananda, wishing to see the Lord.

Ramananda remained in this world after the Lord's disappearance as well. The "Bhakti-ratnakara" tells how the news of it reached Prataparudra:

"Then, hearing the news that the Lord had disappeared from sight, the king, flinging himself down, rolled on the ground. Striking his head with his hands, he fell unconscious; Raya Ramananda alone preserved his life. Unable to bear separation from the Lord, the king stayed some distance away from Nilachala." ("Bhakti-ratnakara", 3.217–219)

Very soon after the Lord's departure the young Srinivasa came to Purushottama. After spending a day with Gadadhara Pandita, he received the darshana of Ramananda, Sarvabhauma, Vakreshvara, Paramananda Puri, Shikhi Mahiti, Vaninatha, Govinda, Shankara and Gopinatha Acharya — all of

them, forgetting food and sleep, were immersed in separation from Gaura:

“All long to see Srinivasa; Srinivasa went to the house of Sarvabhauma. Sri Raya Ramananda came there too; sitting together, the two sing the virtues of Gaurachandra. <…> Both of them are drowning in an ocean of great grief, but seeing Srinivasa, they felt joy in their hearts.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 3.155–156, 158)

There are two traditions about the day of Ramananda’s departure: the krishna-panchami of the month of Jyeshtha or the krishna-panchami of the month of Vaishakha — very likely the same day reckoned by different counts of the months. By our calendar the Disappearance Day of Srila Ramananda Raya is the krishna-panchami of the month of Trivikrama.[8] Neither the year nor the place of his departure is given in the biographies, and nothing is said of a samadhi.

Places of Remembrance

In 1932 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati completed at Udagamandalam a short book in English on the life of Ramananda Raya, and then came to Kovvur on the Godavari — the place of Ramananda’s first meeting with the Lord — and on 5 July, during the days of the Pushkara-yoga, installed the Deities in the Ramananda Gaudiya Math. The math appears in the list of temples of the Gaudiya Math (No. 43: Ramananda Gaudiya Math, P.O. Kovvur, West Godavari). The land at Goshpada-tirtha in the Rajamahendri district was bought for it, and the construction supervised, by Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Gosvami. On 2 September 1951 Srila Bhakti Vilasa Tirtha Gosvami laid the foundation stone of the temple, and on 15 July 1976, having come to Kovvur the day before with forty-two sannyasis and brahmacharis, he installed the Deities of Ramananda and Mahaprabhu on the spot where Sri Chaitanya’s footprints remain. Later the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Ramananda Gaudiya Math was solemnly celebrated in Kovvur.

In the Eternal Pastimes

In the line of Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura, which the Gaudiya Math follows, Ramananda in the Vraja pastimes is Vishakha, just as Svarupa Damodara is Lalita (see the article on Svarupa Damodara). When the Lord, embracing Svarupa and Ramananda, spoke of how Radha reveals to Vishakha the cause of Her anguish (CC, Antya 15.11–12), by some interpretations He was addressing Ramananda as Vishakha. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura in the “Amrita-pravaha-bhashya” (on CC, Madhya 8.23) remarks that the love that flared up between Ramananda and the Lord at their first meeting is the same as Vishakha’s love for Radha and Krishna; hence the Lord saw Vishakha in Ramananda. One of the biographies plainly calls the author of the “Jagannatha-vallabha-nataka” Vishakha-devi in the Vraja-lila, and Svarupa Lalita; and as Lalita and Vishakha are Radha’s intimate friends, so Svarupa and Ramananda are Sri Chaitanya’s intimate associates.

Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” explains his nature differently:

“A certain dear confidential friend [of Krishna], Arjuna, and Arjuna the son of Pandu, uniting together, became Ramananda Raya, dear to the Lord. Therefore the skilful Ramananda day after day described to Gaurachandra the essence of devotion and love for Radha and Krishna. Some call him Lalita, but this is accepted by only a few: for Gaura said to Bhavananda: ‘You are Prithapati.’ The best say that Arjuna, the son of Pandu, having united with the gopi Arjuniya, became Raya Ramananda. ‘And Arjuna, the son of Pandu, at once became the gopi Arjuniya’ — this is clearly stated in the ‘Padma Purana’, ‘Uttara-khanda’. Therefore the venerable Ramananda Raya is these three.” (GGD 120–124)

Thus three were united in Ramananda: Arjuna, Krishna’s close friend in Vraja; Arjuna the Pandava, son of Pandu (no wonder his father Bhavananda is Pandu); and the gopi Arjuniya.[9] So in his service to

Gaura friendship and intimate closeness met: as the cowherd boy Subala gave joy to Krishna, so “Ramaraya” gives joy to Gaura (CC, Antya 6.9), and in Kaviraja’s words his rasa is pure friendship. Murari Gupta records the Lord’s address to him: “bee at the lotus feet of Sri Radhika”.

“Sugar in Thickened Milk”

Such is the life of Ramananda Raya — the governor and poet whom the Lord called one with Himself. Born in a family humble by worldly measure, he became the teacher of sannyasis and pandits; living outwardly as a dignitary and a householder, he was more detached than hermits; serving Jagannatha’s young dancers, he remained unshaken, like wood and stone, for he saw in them only Radha’s friends. Through his lips the Lord revealed to the world the hidden science of rasa, while he himself, in his humility, ascribed everything to the Lord. Krishnadasa Kaviraja concludes the account of the conversations on the Godavari with these words:

“The deeds of Sri Chaitanya may be compared to thickened milk, and Ramananda’s to a mountain of sugar. Their talks on the pastimes of Sri Sri Radha-Krishna are like camphor added to this sweetest thickened milk. Truly fortunate is the one who is blessed to taste it. <…> Millions of times I bow at the feet of Ramananda Raya, through whose lips the Lord Himself revealed to the world the truth about the transcendental rasas.” (CC, Madhya 8.303–304, 310)

1. One of the biographies places the meeting on the Godavari around 1512. By the chronology of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, the Lord left for the south in Vaishakha of the same year in which He took sannyasa — three months after it.

2. Present-day Rajamahendri stands on the northern bank of the Godavari. In Ramananda’s time the capital of this region, Vidyanagara (Vidyapura), lay on the southern bank, near the mouth of the Godavari (Kota-desha), and was then called Rajamahendri; the town has since moved. The northern part of Kalinga was called Utkalinga (Utkala), and Rajamahendri was the southern provincial capital of Utkalinga.

3. The “Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita” of Krishnadasa Kaviraja, which we follow here, places the meeting on the bank of the Godavari near Kovvur, not in a palace in Kanchi-nagara, and says nothing of a vision in meditation. One of the biographies, citing the Madhya-khanda of the “Chaitanya-mangala”, speaks of a meeting on the Godavari and a vision of Rasaraja and Mahabhava; in the poem itself the meeting is told at the beginning of the Shesha-khanda and takes place in Kanchi.

4. According to another biography, Ramananda first met the king in Cuttack, then in Puri, and only after that went to the Lord at Kashi Mishra’s house. According to a third, Ramananda arrived from Vidyanagara at about the same time as Svarupa Damodara came to Puri, and the Lord heard rasa-tattva from his lips.

5. One of the biographies, naming Remuna, allows that it may have been Bhadrak; others say only that Ramananda came with the Lord to Cuttack and accompanied Him beyond the Chitrotpala. One of them calls Ramananda’s companion Mardaraja; in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” he is Mangaraja (Madhya 16.113, 126).

6. So one of the biographies conveys the Lord’s words. The “almost perfect” body awaiting “vastu-siddhi” is only an appearance accepted by an eternally perfect associate for the sake of the pastimes: the Lord Himself says that Ramananda’s body “only seems material” and “in reality it is wholly spiritual” (CC, Antya 5.42).

7. According to one account, Prataparudra pardoned Gopinatha remembering how close he was to the Lord and to Ramananda; according to another, the execution was called off after the minister Harichandana told the king everything.

8. One of the biographies gives both opinions — Jyeshtha krishna-panchami and Vaishakha krishna-panchami; when the months are counted from the full moon (purnimanta) and from the new moon (amanta), they probably coincide. Other biographies do not give the day of his departure.

9. There are other opinions. According to Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura and several biographies, in the Vraja-lila Ramananda is Vishakha (see above); “some”, as the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” itself says, called him Lalita. We translate the line of GGD 122 about this opinion by the edition we follow — “this is accepted by only a few”; two of the biographies read it otherwise — “but others do not agree”; the sense is the same: Karnapura does not accept the identification with Lalita. One of the biographies, retelling Karnapura, adds “or Vishakha” to Arjuniya, but this is not in the text of the GGD. According to the “Gaura-krishnodaya” (1.46), Ramananda is the celestial singer Tumburu, who followed Narada (Srivasa).